

Design director's synthesis & solution set

Reviewer background: systems & combat design on party-scale RPG combat (BG3 lineage), 4X tactical battles (Age of Wonders 4), and large-scale real-time tactics (Total War: Warhammer 3).

Executive diagnosis

I read the four player reviews and then went through the systems myself. Here is the headline, and it is genuinely encouraging: **Isekai Strategem has a stronger systems-and-content foundation than most games at its stage, and a weaker combat-math and battlefield foundation than it needs.** The counter engine, unique behaviors, combo recognizer, Team Efficiency Grade, and the queue/6-phase resolution are real, thoughtful, differentiated systems — the hard, creative part. What's underbuilt is the *arithmetic* the whole thing rests on, and the *battlefield* the whole thing happens in. Those are the cheap fixes, structurally — mostly re-tuning plus one or two systemic additions, not a rebuild.

A-
SYSTEMS / CONTENT
Counters, uniques, TEG, combos

C
CORE COMBAT MATH
Bounded accuracy absent

C-
BATTLEFIELD
No space, coin-flip initiative

C+
TUNING DISCIPLINE
No status/trigger budget

Where all four lenses agree

Independently, the Naruto-Arena vet, the D&D vet, the World Trigger fan, and the tactics player converged on the same four faults. When four different audiences complain about the same thing, it isn't taste — it's design.

Converged fault	NA	D&D	WT	Tactics
The d20 doesn't decide anything (modifiers dwarf the die)	✓ "combos whiff yet the roll is theater"	✓ "no bounded accuracy — the die is decoration"	—	✓ "whiff without tension"
No positioning / spatial decisions	—	—	✓ "WT is all about the map"	✓ "half the genre is absent"
Initiative is a coin flip in a lethal game	—	—	✓ (via one-shots)	✓ "least tactical decision"
Status / trigger power is unbudgeted (outliers)	✓ cd-1 spam	✓ crit & condition math	—	✓ "outliers eat build diversity"

Problem 1 — Restore bounded accuracy (P0, the keystone fix)

Diagnosis. Attack modifiers sit around +26 while Defense sits around +11; damage is dice-plus-a-huge-flat ($2d6+37$, $2d6+45$, $4d8+86$). A d20 swings ± 19 , but a 15-point pre-roll gap and a +45 flat mean the die contributes ~15% to to-hit and ~16% to damage. The game *looks* like a dice game and *plays* like deterministic arithmetic with a cosmetic roll — which is why advantage/disadvantage, crits, and the

defender's roll all feel muted (D&D review), and why planned lines still "whiff" without earning tension (NA/Tactics reviews).

Why it's the keystone. Almost every other complaint is downstream. Fix the accuracy band and your existing advantage system, crit system, and to-hit tension all switch on for free. This is the BG3 lesson: 5e's bounded accuracy is *why* a d20 roll is dramatic at every level.

CONCRETE SOLUTION

Compress the accuracy band ~3–4×. Target: the typical Attack–Defense modifier gap should fall *inside* the d20's range, so the roll is usually 40–60% of the outcome.

- Attack modifier range $\approx +4 \dots +14$; Defense modifier range $\approx +2 \dots +12$ (from today's $\sim +26 / \sim +11$).
- Rebalance damage so **dice $\approx 40\text{--}50\%$ of average**. E.g., `twin_fang_strike` 2d6+37 (dice = 16% of 44) $\rightarrow \sim 5d6+21$ (avg ≈ 38.5 , dice $\approx 45\%$). Keep averages within $\pm 10\%$; just move value from the flat bonus into more/bigger dice.
- Decide: **static Defense (AC-style) or opposed rolls**. I recommend static Defense — it halves variance and log noise and is what bounded accuracy assumes. Keep opposed only if you want a defender-side build axis, and only *after* compression.

This is a spreadsheet pass over 60 triggers + stat blocks, not new code. It is the single highest-leverage change available.

Problem 2 — Add a spatial pillar (P1)

Diagnosis. Two of four reviewers (and the genre) want *space*. "Melee/ranged" are currently inert tags. Without a positional axis, an entire decision family — engage/hold, group/split, protect the back line — doesn't exist, and the World Trigger fantasy (Attacker closing on a Sniper) can't be expressed.

CONCRETE SOLUTION — YOU DON'T NEED A GRID

Add a **front/back row + range-band** layer, the lightest thing that creates real decisions (see: Darkest Dungeon rank system, Banner Saga's line, TWWH3's front-line/artillery logic distilled):

- **Rows:** each squad has a Front and Back row (assign at draft, swap costs an action). Melee triggers hit the enemy Front row unless it's empty; Snipers/Shooters can reach the Back row. Front-row operators soak for the back.
- **Range bands** (even simpler alternative): Close / Mid / Far. Attackers want Close (bonus), Snipers want Far (bonus, penalized Close), Shooters flexible; an action can change band. Now "close the gap" is a real tempo cost, and Trappers can lock a band.

This reuses your existing melee/ranged tags as inputs and turns them into choices. It is the biggest *identity* upgrade you can make.

Problem 3 — Make initiative earned, and soften lethality (P1)

Diagnosis. First-turn is decided by a 50/50 coin flip, and a single attack can delete a unit. The most decisive variable is pure luck — the antithesis of "strategem."

CONCRETE SOLUTION

- **Weight initiative by an earned quantity.** You already compute the Team Efficiency Grade; use it (or a Trion-Affinity/Team-Spirit composite) to bias the flip — e.g., the higher-Grade squad wins the opening ~65/35, or spends a resource to seize it. Randomness the player can *build against*, per the tactics review.
- **Add a downed-but-not-dead state ("Bail Out").** A defeated operator drops to a Bailed state for 1–2 turns (out of the fight, can't be finished) instead of instantly gone. This directly answers the World Trigger fan, softens the one-shot problem, and converts matches from "delete race" to "attrition + objectives." It also makes going-second survivable, reducing the sting of the initiative flip.

Problem 4 — Put status effects and triggers on explicit budgets (P1)

Diagnosis. The condition library is rich but un-costed: `marked` is +50% damage-taken for 1 turn, `exposed` +25% for 2, `petrified` halves damage for 2; DoTs range 8 → 12/turn with no rule; crit chance scales toward ~75%. Players can't intuit relative value, and the AI can't value them either. On the trigger side, a handful of outliers dominate.

SOLUTION A — A STATUS POINT (SP) BUDGET

Cost every status as **SP = magnitude-weight × duration × targets**, and cap the SP a single trigger may carry relative to its Trion cost. Illustrative weights (per target per turn):

Effect class	Example	SP / target-turn
Hard CC (no actions)	stunned, frozen, charmed	3.0
Damage-taken multiplier	marked, exposed (per +25%)	1.5
DoT	bleeding/scorched (per 8 dmg)	1.2
Stat swing	weakened, fatigued (per ~10%)	0.8
Economy denial	sapped, silenced	1.0–1.5

Then `marked` (+50% = 3.0 SP × 1 turn) and `exposed` (+25%×2 = 3.0 SP) land on the *same* budget — now they're intelligible and interchangeable, and a trigger applying a 3-target DoT is visibly "spending" 3× as much.

SOLUTION B — A TRIGGER VALUE BUDGET (AND RE-COST THE OUTLIERS)

Define $\text{Value} = (\text{avg_damage} + \text{SP_value}) \div \text{Trion_cost}$, then multiply by a **cooldown factor** (cd 1 = ×1.5, cd 2 = ×1.0, cd 3 = ×0.8) to price spam. Target a band (say 2.0–3.0 effective). Today's offenders, with fixes:

Trigger	Problem	Fix
<code>whirlwind_slash</code>	cd 1 + 12 Trion + 3-target + bleed = best value in game (my own over-buff)	Move to cd 2 or drop the bleed; raise Trion to ~16.

twin_fang_strike	cd 1, 10 Trion single-target spam — zero tempo decision	cd 2, or make it the deliberate "opener" (First-Strike synergy) at higher cost.
longshot	~104 potential one-shots a 100-HP unit through a die that doesn't matter	Cap single-hit lethality: reduce to ~70 potential, add a self-cost / 1-turn wind-up, or make it Far-band-only (ties to Problem 2).
cinderburst	64 AoE + scorched 12/turn is a double-dip	Pick one axis: big AoE or strong DoT, not both at full value.

Problem 5 — Make Trion the beating heart it pretends to be (P2)

Diagnosis. Two reviewers noted Trion is thematically central but mechanically soft: income is a semi-random tier (10/20/35), most turns you cast once anyway, and capacity rarely bites.

CONCRETE SOLUTION

- **Deterministic (or tight) income** scaled hard by Trion Affinity, so building for economy is a reliable, expressive choice (Naruto-Arena's deterministic chakra is the north star).
- **Make capacity gate burst:** FAT's 3-ability turn should be bounded by capacity, so high-Trion operators are the ones who can unleash — the World Trigger "Trion is destiny" fantasy.
- **Elevate denial as a counter axis:** sapped / genjutsu_trapped / silenced become a real sub-game if income and capacity actually matter.

Problem 6 — Tutorialize the depth (P2)

The World Trigger fan is right that the game front-loads a d20 system, ~60 statuses, a six-sub-score Grade, and FAT before the first punch. The recent battle-log rework (plain-English breakdowns, clickable ability/character popups) is exactly the right instinct — extend it: a story/tutorial that introduces *one pillar per beat* (Trion → Triggers → squad → FAT → Grade), and word-based stat explanations everywhere (as the Team Spirit readout already does). Depth is an asset once it's learnable.

Prioritized roadmap

Pri	Change	Effort	Payoff
P0	Bounded-accuracy re-tune (compress modifiers, move damage into dice, pick static vs opposed)	Med (spreadsheet)	Turns on advantage/crit/to-hit tension across the whole game
P0	Cap crit chance (threshold ≥ 17) & crit dice-only	Low	Removes the delete-lottery
P1	Earned initiative (TEG-weighted) + Bail-Out downed state	Med	Removes the coin-flip; softens one-shots
P1	Spatial pillar (rows or range bands)	Med–High	Adds the missing decision family & the WT dance
P1	Status Point + Trigger Value budgets; re-cost outliers	Med	Legibility, build diversity, AI can value effects

P2	Deterministic Trion income; capacity-gated FAT; denial axis	Med	Makes the theme's core resource matter
P2	Staged tutorialization of the pillars	Med	Converts depth from barrier to draw

Closing note to the team

Don't let the length of this list read as "the game is bad" — it isn't. You've built the expensive, creative layer (differentiated counters, uniques, combos, a genuinely clever risk/reward Grade, a real planning-phase resolution) that most projects never reach. The gaps the four audiences found are, almost entirely, **tuning and two focused systemic additions**. Fix bounded accuracy first (it's the keystone that lights up systems you already own), give the fight a *space* and an *earned* first move, and put your effects on a budget. Do those and you'll have converted a promising systems toy into a game all four of these very different players would keep playing.

Design Director synthesis · Grounded in the live catalog, constants, and the four persona reviews. References: bounded accuracy (BG3/5e), tightly-costed enchantments (Age of Wonders 4), positional roles & front-line logic (Total War: Warhammer 3), controllable-RNG & perfect-information tactics (XCOM, Into the Breach), rank/position combat (Darkest Dungeon), turn-order-as-resource (Banner Saga).